Intro to Claude Cowork

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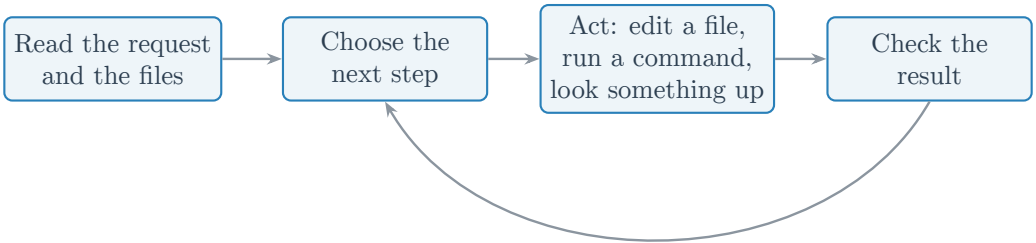
Intro

What is Claude Cowork?

Anthropic describes Cowork as bringing "Claude Code's agentic capabilities to knowledge work beyond coding."

- **You describe the result you want.** Claude plans the steps and carries them out.
- **It works with files in folders you choose.** It reads spreadsheets and documents, and writes new ones.
- **It produces finished files:** spreadsheets, documents, and slide decks.
- **It runs in the Claude desktop app.** In the current app, chat and Cowork start from the same message box.

How it works: a loop



- Each step appears in the task window as it happens. You can stop it or redirect it at any point.
- Because it acts on its own between steps, the instructions and permissions you set matter more than in a chat.

The context window



- Claude works from a limited record of the task, called the **context window**: your request, the skill, the conversation, file contents, and the result of each step.
- Long tasks fill it. When it is nearly full, Claude summarizes earlier work to make room. The summary keeps the main points, not every detail.
- Rules that must hold for the whole task belong in a file, such as a skill, that Claude can read again.

What we'll show today

Demo 1 · Jordan
Building slide decks: what Cowork can make.

Demo 2 · Ted
Tagging repository deposits: where Cowork stops and asks.

Four things to watch for in both demos:

- **Skill files:** written instructions, such as a local policy, that Claude follows each time.
- **Permissions:** Claude works only in folders you connect, and can be set to ask before each action.
- **Stop conditions:** Claude stops and asks when information is missing or it can't check something.
- **Delegation boundary:** some decisions stay with staff, such as approving headings or deleting originals.

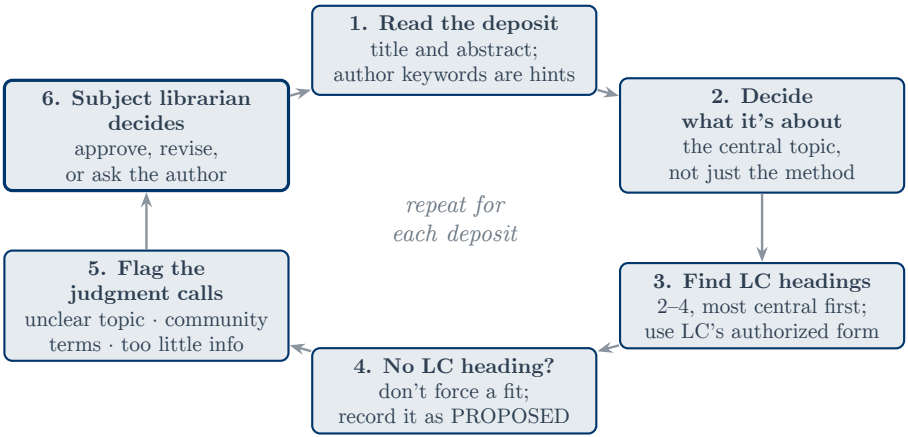
Demo 1

Demo 1

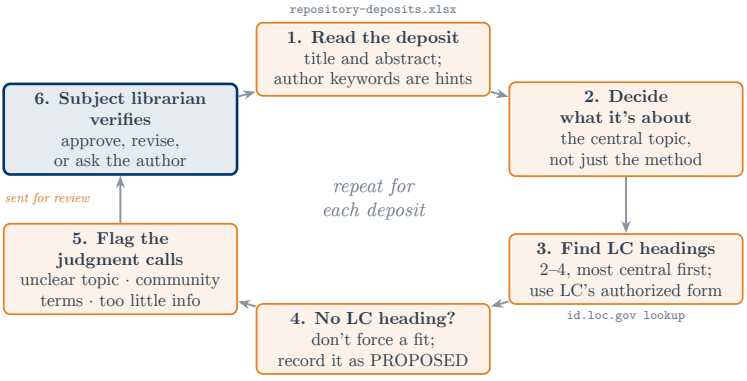
Questions?

Demo 2: Subject Tagging

How subject tagging works today



The same loop, with Claude



Claude does steps 1–5. The rules it follows are written in a **skill**.

The librarian does step 6. Claude sends every flag, PROPOSED term, and unclear topic to the librarian.

`Grey labels` show what Claude reads: the deposits spreadsheet in the connected folder, and LC's lookup service.

The task

Ten new theses and working papers were deposited in the institutional repository this week. Each one needs Library of Congress subject headings. Unclear cases go to a subject librarian.

The policy (how to tag, when to stop, what to send to a librarian) is in a **skill**.

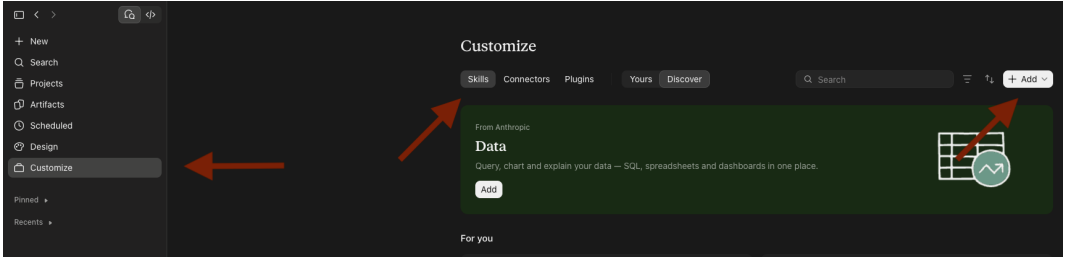
What is a skill?

A skill

A plain-text file of instructions, such as a local policy. Claude loads it when a task matches its description, and follows it each time.

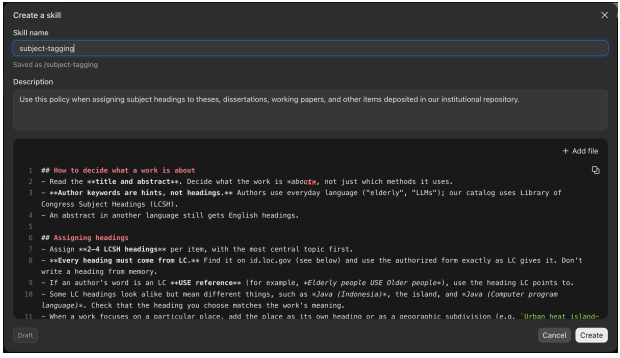
- **No code, no training.** It's ordinary text with headings and bullet points.
- **Name and description** tell Claude *when* to use it.
- **Instructions** tell Claude *how*: the rules, when to stop, and what to send to people.
- **Once saved**, it's available in every new chat.
- **Best for bounded, repetitive tasks with a clear workflow**, like tagging a weekly batch of deposits.

Step 1: Create a skill



1. Click **Customize** in the left sidebar.
2. Open the **Skills** tab.
3. Click + **Add** and create a new skill.

Step 2: Write the skill



- **Skill name:** how you'll recognize it.
- **Description:** tells Claude when to use the skill. *"Use this policy when assigning subject headings to theses, dissertations, working papers, and other items deposited in our institutional repository."*
- **Instructions:** the policy itself, in six sections: how to decide what a work is about · assigning headings · looking up headings at LC · flag for the subject librarian · output · never.
- Click **Create**. It's saved to your account.

Anatomy of a Skill: the rules

What Claude does on every item, in the skill's own words:

- "Read the **title and abstract**. Decide what the work is *about*, not just which methods it uses."
- "**Author keywords are hints, not headings.** Authors use everyday language ('elderly', 'LLMs'); our catalog uses Library of Congress Subject Headings."
- "**Every heading must come from LC.** Find it on id.loc.gov and use the authorized form exactly as LC gives it. Don't write a heading from memory."
- "If an author's word is an LC **USE reference** (for example, *Elderly people USE Older people*), use the heading LC points to."
- "Assign **2–4 LCSH headings** per item, with the most central topic first."
- Every item gets a **Status**: *Ready* (every heading verified, no flags), *Review* (a flag, a PROPOSED term, or an unverified heading), or *Stop* (not enough information).

Anatomy of a Skill: stop conditions

When the answer isn't in the data, Claude **stops and says so** instead of guessing:

- **Not enough information:** *"If the title and abstract don't say what the work is about, **assign nothing** for that item and ask for the full text or the author's input."*
- **No LC heading:** *"If a central concept has no LC heading, don't force a poor fit and don't invent a heading. List the concept as **PROPOSED**."*
- **No guessing about LC:** *"If the service can't be reached, say so in the report. **Don't answer from memory** about whether LC has a heading."*
- **No bot checks:** *"If a bot check, CAPTCHA, or 'verify you are human' page appears anyway, don't try to solve it."*

Anatomy of a Skill: delegation boundaries

The skill lists the decisions Claude must leave to people.

Flag for the subject librarian *(don't decide these yourself)*

- **Primary topic unclear:** *"Give both options and say why."*
- **Terminology concerns:** *"Keep the LC heading, note the preferred term, and flag it. Don't substitute."*

Never

- *"Change or delete* repository-deposits.xlsx*."*
- *"Submit a heading proposal to LC, or add headings to any local list. Only the subject team does that."*
- *"Publish, upload, or send anything. This is a draft for review."*

Skills guide; permissions enforce

Skill = the policy manual

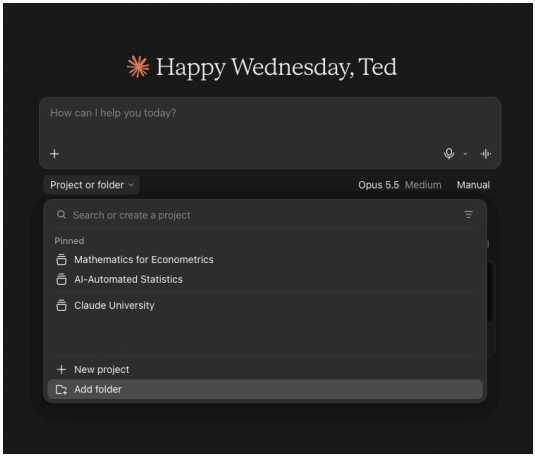
- Written by you, in plain English
- Claude *follows* it
- "Never change or delete repository-deposits.xlsx"

Permissions = the system settings

- Set in the app, not in the text
- Claude *can't get around* them
- It sees only the folder you connect, and must ask before reaching another one

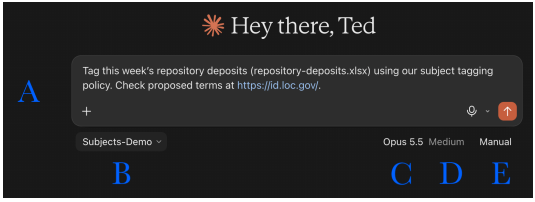
Libraries already work this way: the cataloging manual says what staff should do; ILS permissions control what they can edit.

Step 3: Choose the folder



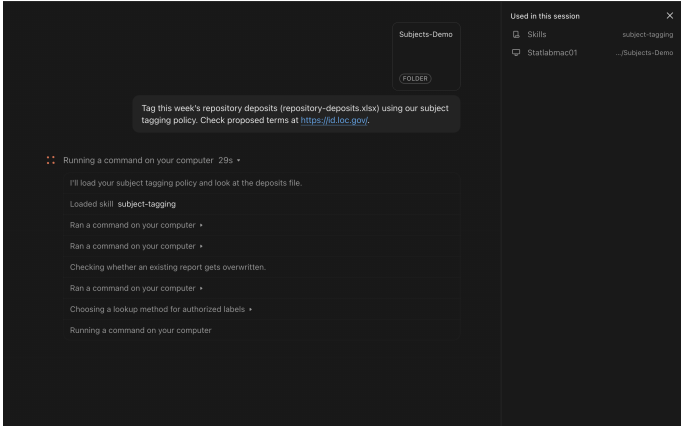
- Below the chat box: **Project or folder → Add folder**.
- Pick **Subjects-Demo**. It holds the deposits spreadsheet.
- **Claude sees only this folder.** The answer key sits in a different folder that isn't connected, so Claude can't read it.
- Need another folder? Claude **has to ask you** first.

Step 4: The prompt window



- **A · Chat box.** The request, in plain English. It names the file and the policy; the LC link says where to check.
- **B · Folder.** What Claude can see and change. **This sets the permissions.**
- **C · Model.** Which Claude does the work (here, Opus 5.5).
- **D · Effort.** How much thinking Claude does before acting. Higher is more careful, but slower.
- **E · Permissions mode.** *Manual:* Claude asks before each action. *Auto:* Claude checks each action for safety and blocks unsafe ones. *Skip:* no checks.

Step 5: The live run



- **"Loaded skill subject-tagging."** Claude matched the request to the skill's description. We never named the file.
- **"Used in this session"** (right panel) lists the skill and the folder Claude used.
- **"Ran a command on your computer"** means reading the spreadsheet, querying LC, or writing the output. Click ▶ to see exactly what ran.

Step 6: The output

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H
1	Deposit ID	Title	Assigned headings (LCSH)	LC links	PROPOSED (no LC heading)	Author keywords (unchanged)	Status	Note for subject librarian
2	DEP-2026-001	Thermal stress and coral bleaching on Caribbean reefs, 2005-2023	Coral bleaching--Caribbean Sea Ocean temperature Coral reef ecology Coral reef conservation	Coral bleaching https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh2007002332.html (geographic subdivision added; Caribbean Area https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85020279.html) Ocean temperature https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85093901.html Coral reef ecology https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85023222.html Coral reef conservation https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh87007158.html	Marine heatwaves — No LC heading found. Related LC headings: Heat waves (Meteorology) https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh90004180.html; Ocean temperature https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85093901.html; Marine ecology https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85081156.html	coral reefs; marine heatwaves; climate change; Caribbean	Review	PROPOSED term: marine heatwaves are the central driver studied; LC has only the atmospheric 'Heat waves (Meteorology)', which isn't a good fit.
3	DEP-2026-002	Alone on the back roads: loneliness among elderly residents of rural Vermont	Loneliness in old age--Vermont Rural older people--Vermont Social isolation--Vermont	Loneliness in old age https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh94006500.html (geographic subdivision added; Vermont https://id.loc.gov/authorities/names/n79007067.html) Rural older people https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85115890.html Social isolation https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85122067.html		elderly; loneliness; rural health; Vermont	Ready	Author keyword 'elderly' → LC 'Elderly people USE Older people'; LC's specific heading 'Loneliness in old age' used.
4	DEP-2026-003	Large language models as writing partners in first-year composition	English language--Rhetoric--Study and teaching (Higher) Artificial intelligence--Educational applications Academic writing Generative artificial intelligence	English language--Rhetoric--Study and teaching (Higher) https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh2009124990.html Artificial intelligence--Educational applications https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh87006783.html Academic writing https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh94009481.html Generative artificial intelligence https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh2024002684.html	Large language models — No LC heading found. Related LC headings: Natural language processing (Computer science) https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh88002625.html; Chatbots https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh2022007792.html; Natural language generation (Computer science) https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh2017004703.html	LLMs; ChatGPT; generative AI; composition pedagogy; academic writing	Review	PRIMARY TOPIC UNCLEAR. Option A (used): English language--Rhetoric--Study and teaching (Higher) — English dept., outcome is argument quality in composition. Option B: Artificial intelligence--Educational applications — the tool under study. Also PROPOSED: Large language models (ChatGPT has no LC heading either).
5	DEP-2026-004	Dating Carolingian manuscripts with machine learning	Paleography, Latin--Data processing Writing, Minuscule Manuscripts, Latin (Medieval and modern) Neural networks (Computer science)	Paleography, Latin https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85097084.html (subdivision added) Writing, Minuscule https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85148650.html Manuscripts, Latin (Medieval and modern) https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85080735.html Neural networks (Computer science) https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh90001937.html		paleography; Carolingian minuscule; neural networks; digital humanities; medieval manuscripts	Ready	Work is about dating manuscripts; machine learning is the method, so paleography is first. 'Carolingian minuscule' has no separate LC heading; 'Writing, Minuscule' covers it.
6	DEP-2026-005	Learning by ear: gamelan pedagogy in Central Java	Gamelan music--Instruction and study--Indonesia--Java Oral tradition--Indonesia--Java Ethnomusicology--Indonesia--Java	Gamelan music https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85052947.html (subdivisions added; Java (Indonesia) https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85009786.html) Oral tradition https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85095251.html Ethnomusicology https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85045421.html		Java; gamelan; music education; oral tradition; ethnomusicology	Ready	Author keyword 'Java' = Java (Indonesia), the island — not Java (Computer program language). Surakarta and Yogyakarta are in LC (sh85141825, n79065178) if more local subdivision is wanted.
7	DEP-2026-006	Muros que recuerdan: memoria colectiva y murales comunitarios en Valparaíso	Mural painting and decoration, Chilean--Chile--Valparaíso Street art--Chile--Valparaíso Collective memory--Chile Chile--History--1988-	Mural painting and decoration, Chilean https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh91006353.html (geographic subdivision added; Valparaíso (Chile) https://id.loc.gov/authorities/names/n85118779.html) Street art https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85128580.html Collective memory https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh2008002444.html (Chile https://id.loc.gov/authorities/n79065124.html) Chile--History--1988- https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh97007051.html		muralismo; memoria colectiva; arte urbano; Valparaíso; Chile	Ready	Spanish abstract; English headings assigned. The 2019 estallido social has no LC event heading; covered by Chile--History--1988-.
8	DEP-2026-007	Speaking with the land: Kanien'kéha revitalization and land-based learning at Akwesasne	Mohawk language--Study and teaching Language revival Land-based education Mohawk Nation at Akwesasne	Mohawk language--Study and teaching https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh2002005104.html Language revival https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85074582.html Land-based education https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh2025001304.html Mohawk Nation at Akwesasne https://id.loc.gov/authorities/names/no2026201.html		Kanien'kéha; Kanien'kéha:ka; language revitalization; land-based education; Akwesasne	Review	TERMINOLOGY CONCERN: the community asks that its own names be used — Kanien'kéha (language) and Kanien'kehá:ka (people). LC headings kept: 'Mohawk language' (no Kanien'kéha variant in LC record) and 'Mohawk Indians.' Author's 'language revitalization' → LC 'Language revival'.
9	DEP-2026-008	Shade and justice: tree canopy, heat, and neighborhood inequality in New Haven	Urban heat island--Connecticut--New Haven Trees in cities--Connecticut--New Haven Environmental justice--Connecticut--New Haven Urban forestry--Connecticut--New Haven	Urban heat island https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85141317.html (geographic subdivision added; New Haven (Conn.) https://id.loc.gov/authorities/names/n79100828.html) Trees in cities https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85137261.html Environmental justice https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh97002483.html Urban forestry https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85141316.html		urban heat; tree canopy; environmental justice; New Haven	Ready	
10	DEP-2026-009	Working paper no. 3				robustness; specification	Stop	NOT ENOUGH INFORMATION: title and abstract don't say what the paper is about (only 'extends the framework... robustness checks'). No headings assigned. Request full text or author input.
11	DEP-2026-010	Doomscrolling and sleep quality among graduate students	Sleep Social media--Psychological aspects Graduate students Anxiety	Sleep https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85123396.html Social media https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh2006007023.html (subdivision added) Graduate students https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85056177.html Anxiety https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85008685.html	Doomscrolling — No LC heading found. Related LC headings: Social media addiction https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh2014001723.html; Compulsive behavior https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh85029465.html; News audiences https://id.loc.gov/authorities/subjects/sh96008556.html	doomscrolling; sleep; social media; graduate students; anxiety	Review	PROPOSED term: doomscrolling is the central behavior studied and has no LC heading.

A new file, **repository-deposits.xlsx**, with one row per deposit. The original spreadsheet is untouched.

How to read the output

Read **Status** first, then the **Note** for every row that isn't green.

- **Assigned headings (LCSH):** 2–4 per deposit, most central topic first, each found and verified at id.loc.gov.
- **LC links:** one link per heading, to LC's record. Click any of them to check.
- **PROPOSED (no LC heading):** concepts LC doesn't have a heading for, with related LC headings for the librarian to consider.
- **Author keywords (unchanged):** compare with the assigned headings to see how everyday words became LC headings.
- **Status:** Ready Review Stop.
- **Note for subject librarian:** the reason behind every Review and Stop.

This run: 5 Ready · 4 Review · 1 Stop, with 49 links to LC records.

Reading the decisions: rules applied

Deposit	What Claude did	Skill rule
002 Loneliness, rural Vermont	Author's "elderly": LC says *Elderly people USE Older people.* Claude used *Loneliness in old age--Vermont* and *Rural older people--Vermont.*	"If an author's word is an LC USE reference, use the heading LC points to."
005 Gamelan in Central Java	*Gamelan music--Instruction and study--Indonesia--Java*, using *Java (Indonesia)*, **not** *Java (Computer program language)*	"Some LC headings look alike but mean different things."
006 Murals in Valparaíso	Spanish abstract → *Mural painting and decoration, Chilean--Chile--Valparaíso*; *Street art*; *Collective memory*	"An abstract in another language still gets English headings."
010 Doomscrolling and sleep	PROPOSED *Doomscrolling*: "No LC heading found." Related: *Social media addiction*, *Compulsive behavior*	"If a central concept has no LC heading ... list the concept as PROPOSED."

Reading the decisions: sent to the librarian

Deposit	What the Note says	Skill rule
003 Large language models in first-year composition	"PRIMARY TOPIC UNCLEAR. Option A (used): *English language--Rhetoric--Study and teaching (Higher)* ... Option B: *Artificial intelligence--Educational applications* — the tool under study."	"Give both options and say why."
007 Kanien'kéha revitalization at Akwesasne	"TERMINOLOGY CONCERN: the community asks that its own names be used — Kanien'kéha (language) and Kanien'kehá:ka (people). LC headings kept: 'Mohawk language' (no Kanien'kéha variant in LC record) ..."	"Keep the LC heading, note the preferred term, and flag it. Don't substitute."
009 "Working paper no. 3"	"NOT ENOUGH INFORMATION: title and abstract don't say what the paper is about ... No headings assigned. Request full text or author input."	"Assign nothing for that item."

Q&A

Q&A